

Ohio Truck Factory Layoffs Highlight a Region's Uneven Economic Change

From: PBS NewsHour Mined: 2026-10-03 5 min read

Nearly 1,400 workers were laid off on Wednesday, September 30, at a Springfield, Ohio, truck factory formerly known as Navistar. The job losses were large enough to roughly erase an entire year's **employment** growth in the greater Dayton area, according to the report.

The layoffs affected families. Worker Kyle Bos, who has two daughters and another child due in January, described rising grocery costs alongside losing his job. Bos, a United Auto Workers member, said he planned to **campaign** for Democrats before November's election. He had voted for President Donald Trump three times but said he was done supporting him.

The layoffs came three days before Trump's Saturday rally at a nearby high school. Trump has been arguing that the economy is stronger than many voters believe. At a Texas truck plant on Thursday, he said **manufacturing** was returning and blamed poor public relations for negative views of the economy.

Dayton's industrial history helps explain why factory **employment** matters locally. The Wright brothers' airplane, the cash register, the stepladder and the electric car starter were all invented in the city. Yet federal data show that the surrounding area has lost about half of the 90,000 factory jobs it had in 1990.

The report describes **production** shifting to places where auto parts could be made more cheaply, with the trend accelerating after China joined the World Trade Organization. The region's economy has since developed other sources of **employment**.

Wright-Patterson Air Force Base has expanded and directly employs 38,000 people. **Innovations** associated with the base have attracted aerospace businesses, including Joby Aviation, Sierra Nevada Corporation and Electra. Aerospace businesses work on aircraft and related technology.

The White House cited Electra's \$850 million **investment** and announcements from Honda, Stellantis and other companies as evidence that Trump's policies were creating jobs. Jeff Hoagland, who leads the Dayton Development Coalition, said the region's recovery reflected recognition by both Republicans and Democrats of Wright-Patterson's value over two decades.

Hoagland emphasized that economic development takes time. The layoffs and new **investments** show how different parts of one region's economy can move in different directions.

Word Treasure

employment -- Work that people do for pay.

campaign -- Work to persuade people to support a candidate or party.

manufacturing -- Making products, often in factories.

production -- The process of making goods.

innovations -- New ideas, methods or technologies.

investment -- Money put into a business or project to help it develop.

Background you need

Manufacturing means making products, often in factories.

Aerospace businesses work on aircraft and related technology.

The article describes both factory job losses and other sources of employment in the Dayton region.

Break it down

The opening gives the layoffs' date, location and scale.

The next section describes Kyle Bos's family concerns and political plans.

The article explains the timing of Trump's rally and attributes his economic position.

It reviews Dayton's industrial history and the decline in factory employment.

It describes Wright-Patterson's expansion and the aerospace businesses it attracted.

The ending attributes the White House's investment claims and Hoagland's explanation of recovery.

Why it matters

The story connects family income, regional employment and election choices. It shows how factory job losses and investment in other industries can occur in the same region.

Test what you remember

1. **When did the Springfield truck factory layoffs happen?**
 - (A) Three days before Trump's nearby rally
 - (B) Three weeks before Trump's nearby rally
 - (C) Three days after Trump's nearby rally
 - (D) Three weeks after Trump's nearby rally
2. **What political plan did Kyle Bos describe?**
 - (A) Campaigning for Democrats before November's election
 - (B) Campaigning for Republicans before November's election
 - (C) Running for the House in November's election
 - (D) Running for the Senate in November's election
3. **What did Trump blame for negative views of the economy?**
 - (A) Lower factory productivity
 - (B) Poor public relations
 - (C) Less grocery shopping
 - (D) Fewer aircraft inventions
4. **What does the article report about factory employment since 1990?**
 - (A) The area lost about half its factory jobs
 - (B) The area kept nearly all its factory jobs
 - (C) The area doubled its number of factory jobs
 - (D) The area added about half as many factory jobs
5. **What helped attract aerospace businesses to the area?**
 - (A) Innovations associated with Wright-Patterson
 - (B) Public relations associated with the rally
 - (C) Price changes associated with grocery stores
 - (D) Campaigns associated with November's election
6. **How did Hoagland explain the region's recovery?**
 - (A) Both parties recognized Wright-Patterson's value over time
 - (B) Only Democrats recognized Wright-Patterson's value over time
 - (C) Neither party recognized Wright-Patterson's value over time
 - (D) Only Republicans recognized Wright-Patterson's value over time

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: A 3: B 4: A 5: A 6: A

Questions to think about

1. **Kyle Bos:** He described rising grocery costs and losing his job. After voting for Trump three times, he said he planned to campaign for Democrats.
2. **Donald Trump:** He argued that manufacturing was returning and blamed poor public relations for negative views of the economy.
3. **The White House:** It cited Electra's investment and other company announcements as evidence that Trump's policies were creating jobs.
4. **Jeff Hoagland:** He credited both parties with recognizing Wright-Patterson's value over two decades and emphasized that economic development takes time.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):